

Triplets and tuplets

In music notation, triplet means three notes in the time of two. Tuplet is a generic term meaning x notes in the time of y, where x and y are two numbers.

SEE ALSO

◀ 18–19 Notes on the staff

◀ 26–27 Note values

◀ 30–31 Time signatures

◀ 36–37 Grouping notes

Triplets

Triplets and tuplets enable us to write rhythms that do not fit the meter in a regular way. A triplet is a group of three notes in the time of two. It is indicated by writing a 3 over or under the group of notes.

▷ 3 in the time of 2

Triplet rhythms are quite common. They usually occur where most of the note values are regular divisions or subdivisions into two.



The 3 is usually written on the stem side of the notes.



Triplet group

△ How to write a triplet quarter note group

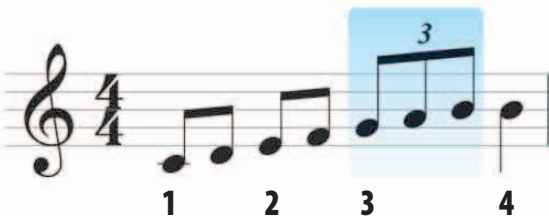
For quarter notes, or any notes without a beam, the 3 is combined with a bracket to show which notes are in the triplet.

△ How to write a triplet eighth note group

For a group of beamed eighth notes or sixteenth notes, the bracket is generally not needed. The 3 is usually written next to the beam.

Triplets in action

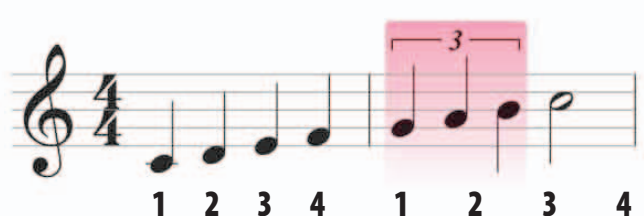
Here are two examples of triplets in action—a simple upward scale, notated first using eighth notes, then using quarter notes. Try to sing it, or imagine the rhythm in your head, keeping the beats regular so that you can hear the effect of the triplet rhythm.



△ Triplet eighth notes

Shown here is a group of triplet eighth notes on the third beat. They are played, or sung, in the time of two ordinary eighth notes.

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△ Triplet quarter notes

In the second measure, the three triplet quarter notes cross the second beat, with the bracket indicating which quarter notes form the triplet group.

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